

Handout - *Gilbert Ryle, “Imaginary Objects”*

The Problem and the Proposed Solution

Ryle begins from what looks like a straightforward philosophical puzzle: we ordinarily and intelligibly say things like “**Mr Pickwick is an imaginary being**” or “**Sea-serpents are fictitious monsters**.” Yet these claims seem to collide with another thought that is equally obvious in ordinary language: imaginary things are *not real*. So how can we truly speak *about* Mr Pickwick if there is no such being? The temptation is to infer that there must be some peculiar class of entities—*imaginary objects*—which enjoy a strange, diminished, or derivative mode of being. That is the target of Ryle’s critique. He thinks the traditional framing of the issue is already corrupted by a logical mistake: it assumes both that there are different “statuses” of being and that imaginary objects form a species of object at all (pp. 66–67).

Ryle’s solution is to **dissolve** the metaphysical puzzle by means of logical analysis. *Imaginariness is not a property*, and “Mr Pickwick is an imaginary being” is not really a proposition *about* some object. Rather, it is a disguised way of saying that expressions such as “**Mr Pickwick**” function as **pseudo-designations**: they look like names, but in fact designate nothing. The real task, then, is not to determine the ontological status of imaginary entities, but to explain how language can **seem** to be about something where nothing answers to the apparent designation (pp. 67–69).

1. *Imaginariness is not a property*

Ryle’s opening move is strongly anti-Meinongian. He rejects the idea that predicates like “**exists**,” “**is real**,” “**is an entity**,” and “**is imaginary**” name genuine properties comparable to *red*, *hot*, or *tiger*. Existence is not one attribute among others. There are not, for example, two species of dachshund—real ones and unreal ones. To say that something exists is not to add a further feature to it; rather, it is just to say, in a different logical idiom, that there is something answering to the relevant description (pp. 67–68).

This is the core of the essay. Ryle is applying a familiar logical point: **existence-claims are not ordinary predications**. Hence it is a grammatical illusion to treat “imaginary” as if it were a property possessed by some item. An “imaginary elephant” is not a special elephant with the property of unreality. Strictly speaking, there is no such elephant there to possess any property

at all. What exists are acts of imagining, stories, pictures, and descriptions—not a further ontological category of the imaginary object.

2. The shift from “What is Mr Pickwick?” to “What are these propositions really about?”

Ryle’s next major move is methodological. He says the wrong question is: **What sort of object is Mr Pickwick?** The right question is: **What is going on in propositions that grammatically appear to be about Mr Pickwick?** (p. 69).

He distinguishes **three classes of propositions**:

- **Fictional propositions within the novel:** e.g. Dickens writes, “Mr Pickwick visited Rochester.”
- **Readerly propositions about the novel:** e.g. “Mr Pickwick did not visit Oxford.”
- **Philosophers’ propositions:** e.g. “Mr Pickwick is an imaginary object.”

These are not logically homogeneous. Their truth-conditions differ:

- Dickens’ fictional sentences are **not about anyone**, though they *pretend* to be.
- Readers’ remarks are really **about the book** and what it says or implies.
- Philosophers’ remarks are about either fictional sentences or readerly discourse about those sentences (pp. 69, 73–74).

Instead of postulating occult entities, Ryle views his task as that of separating the uses of language that have been collapsed together.

3. “About”-ness and pseudo-designation

A central section of the paper asks: **what does it mean for a proposition to be *about* something?** Ryle’s answer is tied to reference conditions. A proposition is about Mont Blanc only if there really is that mountain answering to the designation “Mont Blanc.” A designation can succeed or fail. If it fails, the sentence may still be intelligible, but it is not *about* anything (pp. 70–72).

This leads to one of the essay’s key notions:

Pseudo-designation = an expression that *looks* like a name or referring phrase but in fact designates nothing.

Examples:

- “Mr Pickwick”
- “the first Atlantic swimmer” (if there was none)
- “Rumtifo,” in Ryle’s invented fairy-tale example

The important claim is not that such expressions are meaningless. They are perfectly meaningful. We understand **what would have to be the case** for them to apply. But that is different from there actually being something they designate. Hence fictional discourse is intelligible without ontological commitment to fictional beings.

This distinction also lets Ryle mark the contrast between **fiction** and **lying**:

- A **lie** is false *of something real*.
 - A **fictional sentence** is not false of anything, because nothing answers to its pseudo-designation (p. 72).
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4. Readers, critics, and philosophers: what are *they* talking about?

When readers say, “**Mr Pickwick did not visit Oxford**,” they are not checking railway logs or hotel registers. They are checking the text. That reveals the real logical subject matter: the proposition is shorthand for something like “**The novel does not say or imply that Mr Pickwick visited Oxford**.” So readerly discourse is really **metatextual** (pp. 73–74).

Likewise, when philosophers say “**Mr Pickwick is an imaginary entity**,” what they are really saying is that “**Mr Pickwick**” is a **pseudo-designation**. They are not attributing any ontological status to a person; they are diagnosing the semantic role of a certain class of expressions.

“Mr Pickwick is an imaginary entity” = “Mr Pickwick’ designates no one.”

That is the essay’s deflationary core.

5. Imagining is always imagining *that* something is the case

The final third of the paper shifts from logic to phenomenology. Ryle now asks: what is the act of imagining? His answer is that **imagining is always propositional**. We do not fundamentally imagine *objects*; we imagine **that something is the case** (pp. 74–76).

This is important because many philosophers assume that imagining must involve a peculiar intentional object. Ryle denies this. Imagining is more like:

- believing that ...
- supposing that ...
- guessing that ...

than like:

- seeing an object
- striking an object
- making an object

This means that even apparently object-directed imagination (“I imagine Mr Pickwick”) is analyzable as imagining that someone has such-and-such a complex of properties.

Imaging vs. imagining

Ryle also sharply distinguishes **imaging** from **imagining**:

- I may imagine in words, images, or both.
- Mental images themselves are not guarantees of objects.
- An image may be *as if of* a sea-serpent without there being any sea-serpent (pp. 75–76).

This is an anticipatory strike against the “mental content” theory: a picture in the mind is no better than a descriptive phrase at securing an object.

6. Constructive imagination and the “creation” of characters

Ryle ends by addressing literary creativity. Did Dickens **create** Mr Pickwick? In one ordinary sense, yes; but philosophically, no. What Dickens created was not an entity, but a **complex predicate**, a richly elaborated seeming-description of a person (pp. 80–83).

That is why Ryle says constructive imagination is really a form of **internal storytelling**. The novelist does not first inspect a private object and then report on it. Rather, the imagining itself consists in fabricating an interconnected tale: “someone was so-and-so, did such-and-such, suffered thus-and-so ...” (pp. 80–81).

This culminates in a powerful anti-reification claim:

- Dickens did **not** create a strange person with a special ontological status.
- He created a **story**, or better, a **seeming description-of-a-somebody**.